Guest Lecture 2: The Psychology, Biology, and Politics of Food

Introduction to Psychology · Yale University, Spring 2007 · Professor Kelly Brownell

Study guide based on the official course overview. Source: https://oyc.yale.edu/psychology/psyc-110/guest-lecture-2 (CC BY-NC-SA 3.0).

Note: Open Yale Courses published no transcript for this guest lecture. This short guide is based on the official overview only.

Before you start

In this guest lecture, Professor Kelly Brownell talks about why people eat what they do, and what might be done to improve diet in the U.S. and around the world.

Learning goals

After this lecture you should be able to:

- Name the main topics of the lecture.
- Explain what "economic factors" and "food marketing" mean.
- Describe the idea of changing nutrition through legislation.

Key ideas

1. Why people eat what they do

The lecture covers the reasons people eat what they do, with emphasis on the economic factors that drive food choices.

2. Food, marketing and the food industry

It discusses the benefits and disadvantages of modern food and agriculture approaches. It also looks at how biology intersects with (connects to) food marketing practices, and at the role of the food industry.

3. Improving diet through law

A key area of focus is novel (new) approaches to changing nutrition through legislation and legal approaches.

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning in simple English	Example from the lecture
nutrition	the food we take in and its effect on the body	changing nutrition through law
agriculture	farming: growing plants and raising animals for food	modern agriculture approaches
economic factors	things related to money	factors that drive food choices

Term	Meaning in simple English	Example from the lecture
food marketing	the ways companies advertise and sell food	marketing practices and biology
legislation	laws, or making laws	novel legal approaches

Check your understanding

1. What are the areas of emphasis in this lecture?
2. What does the lecture cover about modern food and agriculture?
3. What does "economic factors that drive food choices" mean?
4. What is a key area of focus for changing nutrition?

Answer guide

1. Economic factors behind food choices, biology and food marketing, and the food industry.
2. Their benefits and disadvantages.
3. Things related to money that influence which foods people choose.
4. Novel legislation and legal approaches.

English practice

Useful phrases from the lecture (These phrases come from the official overview.)

- "This lecture covers ..." - introduces the topics of a talk.
- "the benefits and disadvantages of ..." - shows both sides of something.
- "... is a key area of focus." - marks the most important topic.

Speaking task (with your AI tutor)

- Say what this lecture is about in 4-6 sentences. Use "economic factors", "food marketing" and "legislation".

Writing task

- Write one paragraph (80-120 words) summarizing what this lecture covers, according to the overview.

Study with your tutor

Things to say to your tutor in Live conversation:

- "Let's review Guest Lecture 2. Ask me questions about the overview, one at a time."
- "Quiz me on the key vocabulary of Guest Lecture 2."
- "I will summarize Guest Lecture 2 in my own words. Check my understanding and my English."

Readings from the original course

- Brownell. K.D., and Yach, D. "The Battle of the Bulge." Foreign Policy (November/December 2005). pp. 26-27
- Brownell, K.D., and Willett, W.C. "Choose to Remove Trans Fats (OpEd)." San Francisco Chronicle (October 18, 2006). pp. B8
- Yach, D, Stuckler, D., and Brownell, K.D. "Epidemiologic and Economic Consequences of the Global Epidemics of Obesity and Diabetes." Nature Medicine, 12 (2006). pp. 62-66
- Brownell, K.D., and Nestle, M. "The Sweet and Lowdown on Sugar (OpEd)." New York Times (January 23, 2004). pp. A23

My notes